

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Getty Images

Iranian state media claimed to have a draft of a peace deal with America. If agreed, it would see America move its troops away from Iran and lift its naval blockade. Iran would allow commercial shipping through the Strait of Hormuz at pre-war levels within a month. The White House called the report a “complete fabrication”. In a cabinet meeting, Donald Trump said America is “not satisfied” with proposals.

The **World Health Organisation** called for a ceasefire in the east of the Democratic Republic of **Congo**, which has seen most cases in the latest [Ebola outbreak](#). Over 900 have been reported there. Fighting between the army and M23, a militia backed by Rwanda, has hindered response efforts and exacerbated the spread. Meanwhile Canada and the Bahamas imposed similar travel bans to America’s on residents from three African countries.

Israel’s armed forces ordered the evacuation of Tyre, a Lebanese city, as it carried out air strikes in southern and eastern Lebanon, despite a ceasefire agreement. Israel claimed to have struck more than 100 targets in Lebanon on Tuesday, killing at least 31 people, including children. Israel earlier said that it had killed the new leader of the armed wing of Hamas in an airstrike on Gaza.

Ukraine's president, Volodymyr Zelensky, appealed to Donald Trump and America's Congress for more Patriot PAC-3 missiles and other air-defence systems to counter missile attacks by Russia. In a letter, Mr Zelensky wrote that deliveries were "no longer keeping up with the reality of the threat we face" as America diverted weapons to the war in Iran.

South Africa's government, along with lobby groups representing [the country's](#) white Afrikaner minority population, dismissed claims by the Trump administration that white South Africans are facing an "unforeseen emergency refugee situation". Mr Trump blamed South Africa's leadership for what he called a surge in "racially motivated violence". Their rebuttal comes as America prepares to accept 10,000 additional white South Africans as refugees this year.

Donald Trump's net approval rating has hit a new low, according to *The Economist's* [presidential tracker](#). At -24 points, he is the most unpopular American president since our poll started in 2009. The war in Iran has hurt Mr Trump's standing. But it's his handling of the economy that is really dragging him down.

New York and New Jersey are investigating FIFA over allegations of [inflated](#) pricing and misleading ticketing procedures for upcoming [World Cup](#) football matches. The joint probe follows complaints by fans that they were assigned worse seats than they had paid for. Investigators will focus on the eight matches scheduled at the MetLife Stadium in New Jersey, including the final in July.

Figure of the day: \$64trn. The value of companies' total offshore assets. Read about [why tax havens are thriving](#) despite crackdowns.



Photograph: Getty Images

America's mixed messaging

At times, Donald Trump seems to be negotiating with himself. After dropping heavy hints over the weekend of an imminent peace deal, America then dropped missiles on southern Iran on Monday. The combatants are still discussing an interim deal to extend their ceasefire and reopen the Strait of Hormuz. Iran's demand for immediate sanctions relief and the fate of its stockpile of highly-enriched uranium remain sticking points.

In one social-media post on Monday, Mr Trump seemed prepared to accept Iran's uranium being "destroyed in place", rather than his oft-repeated demand that it be shipped outside the country first. But another Trumpian missive urged Arab and Muslim-majority countries to recognise Israel at the end of the war. They will almost certainly decline to do so. The request was a sign of how poorly the emerging accord with Iran is viewed by hawkish Republicans: Mr Trump is desperate to sweeten the deal.



Photograph: Getty Images

Africa's Christian conservatives convene

Right-wing Christians from across Africa descend on Accra, Ghana's capital, this week for the “Pan-African Conference on Family Values”. Delegates will discuss how to resist the alleged threats of secular liberalism. But the cross-denominational shindig—which was first held in 2023, and is sponsored by powerful conservative Christian groups from the West—is also a platform to promote a proposed “African charter” on family values. That includes curbing sex education in schools and limiting reproductive rights.

This conservative movement has [gained momentum](#) in recent years. Governments are becoming more receptive to their demands. In February 2025 Ghanaian lawmakers reintroduced a controversial anti-gay bill; in April, a Kenyan court struck down a ruling affirming the right to abortion. Though delegates in Accra will surely play up a sense of peril, these days their liberal rivals have more reason to worry.



Photograph: Getty Images

Britain and Poland find common ground

The British government, struggling domestically, has recently found some solace abroad. Since Labour assumed office in 2024, Britain has signed a new “strategic partnership” with [Norway](#) and agreements to “co-ordinate” nuclear weapons with France and increase defence [co-operation with Germany](#). On Thursday, Sir Keir Starmer, the prime minister, is expected to add a new [defence and security treaty](#) with Poland to that list.

The two countries have similar outlooks on sanctions against Russia and support for Ukraine. They already signed smaller agreements, in 2017 and 2023, to boost collaboration in fields such as military training and cyber-security. The new pact will focus more specifically on economic resilience, energy security, illegal migration and crime, and foster greater co-operation between the two countries’ defence industries. It may only partially allay some other tensions, though. Poland worries that Britain’s tighter diplomacy with France and Germany could lead to its being sidelined from a post-war settlement in Ukraine.



Photograph: Reuters

Hong Kong airport's plan for a better tomorrow

Passengers flying from Hong Kong International Airport on Wednesday should double-check their destination before hopping into a cab: terminal two finally reopened, having closed in 2019 for refurbishment. Initially, it will house mostly budget and short-haul carriers.

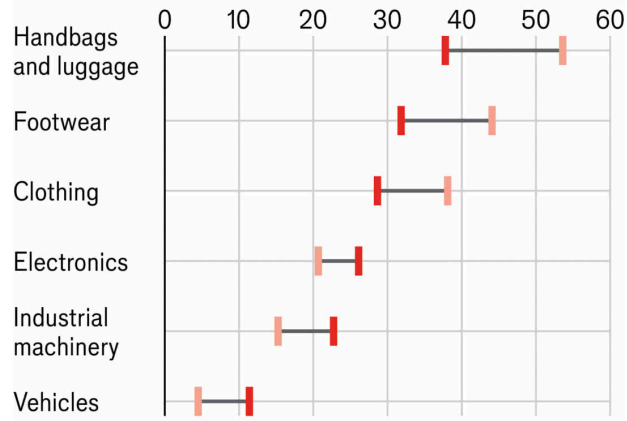
The move is part of Hong Kong's plan to solidify its status as a regional air-transport hub. Over the past decade HKIA has reclaimed a patch of land the size of Gibraltar, revamped terminal one and added a third runway. The new terminal is meant to wow passengers, whose numbers are still down since the pandemic.

Still, tourists may count for less than cargo. Last year HKIA moved more than 5m tonnes, making it the world's busiest cargo airport for the 15th time since 2010. The renovations are also meant to help it shift more goods from mainland China to the rest of the world. With [China's exports on the rise](#), that strategy will probably fly.

Super market

China, share of global exports, %

2014 2024



Sources: BACI; World Bank WITS; *The Economist*



Photograph: Alexander Hammer/Room to Move

A new documentary on dance and difference

“Room to Move” may appear to be about dance. It is really about neurodivergence. The acclaimed documentary, streaming on Netflix from Wednesday, follows Jenn Freeman, a choreographer in her 30s who is losing her connection to her lifelong passion when she is diagnosed with autism spectrum disorder. Though shaken, Ms Freeman is also given a new perspective on her life, allowing her to recognise her dancing as having originated in “stimming”—the repetitive self-stimulation through which many autistic people regulate anxiety or other intense emotions.

Alexander Hammer, the director, deploys an immersive style reminiscent of both “Moonage Daydream” and “Afternoons Of Solitude”—two recent documentaries about David Bowie and bullfighting, respectively. This helps the viewer experience Ms Freeman’s life as she does: seeing what she sees and feeling what she feels (at least a little). In doing so, it provides a rare insight into how a neurodivergent person understands the world.



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Wednesday: Robert Johnson and Muddy Waters were pioneers in which music genre?

Tuesday: Which architect designed the Guggenheim museum in New York?

*It is not half so important to know
as to feel.*

Rachel Carson